



11 Individual oral: global issue in literary and non-literary works

Individual assessment · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The individual oral is a spoken assessment in which students identify a global issue of their choice and explore how it is presented through the content and form of extracts from works studied, connecting literary technique to a real-world concern. Students must justify their extract choices, analyse specific techniques (not just theme), and demonstrate how the chosen global issue is embedded in the works' craft, not simply mentioned in their subject matter.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A global issue such as 'the erosion of trust in institutions' could be explored through an extract where an invented court scene uses clipped, interrupted dialogue to dramatise a witness being repeatedly cut off. A model oral point: 'The technique of interrupted dialogue formally enacts the erosion of trust by denying the witness narrative control, so the global issue is visible in the extract's dramatic form, not merely its subject matter.' This shows the issue grounded in technique, not just topic.

Quick check · multiple choice

In the individual oral, students must primarily demonstrate:

- A Memorised biographical facts about each author
- B How a global issue is presented through the content AND form (technique) of chosen extracts
- C A comparison of exam board grading criteria
- D A retelling of each work's full plot

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Choose a generic global issue (e.g. displacement, inequality, or environmental degradation) and briefly outline how you would select two extracts from works studied to explore it, specifying at least one literary/technical feature from each extract you would analyse in the oral. [30]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [30]

- Step 1: state the global issue clearly and specifically (e.g. 'displacement caused by environmental change' rather than just 'the environment').
- Step 2: select Extract A and identify a specific technique to analyse (e.g. fragmented, non-chronological structure mirroring a character's disrupted sense of home).
- Step 3: select Extract B (ideally offering a contrasting formal approach) and identify its technique (e.g. a recurring image of an object left behind, functioning as a symbol of severed belonging).
- Step 4: plan a comparative link between the two extracts' techniques, showing how each work's form — not just its plot — embodies the chosen global issue.
- Step 5: prepare to justify extract selection if asked in the follow-up discussion, explaining why these specific passages (rather than others) best illustrate the issue through craft.

Quick check answer

B. The oral requires linking the global issue to specific technique and form in the extracts, not just summarising content or biography.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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